State" terrorist organization, which began a genocidal rampage through Syria and northern Iraq during the summer of 2014). This putatively anti-Zionist rhetoric often rests upon more established, familiar antisemitic notions, as when Jewish communities stand accused, through their continued support for Israel, of placing tribal loyalties above fealty to the nations in which they live. Furthermore, non-Israel related challenges confronted by diaspora Jewish communities—most obviously, the campaign among parliamentarians and animal "rights" groups in several European states to outlaw, in the name of humanitarianism, essential Jewish rituals such as *shechita*, the slaughtering of animals so that they are fit for kosher consumption, and *brit milah*, the circumcision of eight-day-old male infants in accordance with the Abrahamic covenant—summon the ghosts of old and compel the question of why, exactly, legislative measures enacted by the Nazi regime are once again being proposed in democratic states.[3]

Memory, however, is not always the best guide to the contemporary expression of a problem. Hence, the above summary would be sorely compromised without an important qualifier. Without making light of the persistence of antisemitism in our own time, and without denying that there are certain trans-historical antisemitic tropes that we still encounter today, such as the longstanding slur in the Islamic world that the Jews are the "descendants of apes and pigs," it is vital that any discussion of contemporary antisemitism not be restricted to the realms of ideas and discourse. To properly grasp the nature of the threat, our point of departure should begin with the material and political status of Jewish communities themselves. For it is precisely here that we can appreciate the critical difference between present and past: namely, that the Jewish people now are freer and, critically, more empowered than at any other time since the American and French Revolutions ushered in a new era of representative government at the close of the eighteenth century.

AN AGE OF EMPOWERMENT

In the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, when modern antisemitism crystallized, the Jewish experience of it was defined by three factors: first, the existence of discriminatory legislation; second, a marked tendency towards mass violence, either sanctioned, or colluded in, by the state and the authorities; and third, the absence of Jewish sovereignty, which meant that Jews as minority communities were dependent for their security upon the states in which they lived.

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